herself been training as a singer– and they had suffered horribly from near starvation and exposure to the cold winter".

For months they had barely kept themselves alive in a sort of shelter they built with their own hands amidst the **rubble.** Then for three years the Germans ruled the city. The boys grew to hate the Germans. When the resistance movement began secretly to form they were among the first to join. When the war was over, and we had peace at last, they came back to their beloved sister. And they found her –suffering from tuberculosis of the spine."



She paused, took a quick breath. "Did they give up? I do not have to answer that question. They brought her here, persuaded us to take her into the hospital. In the twelve months she has been our patient she has made good progress. There is every hope that one day she will walk– and sing–again."

"Of course, everything is so difficult now, food so scarce and dear, we could not keep going unless we charged a fee. But every week, Lucia's brothers have made their payment." She added simply, "I don't know what they do, I do not ask. Work is scarce in Verona. But whatever it is, I know they do it well."

"Yes," I agreed. "They couldn't do it better."

I waited outside until the boys rejoined me, and then drove them back to the city. They sat beside me, not speaking. For my part, I did not say a word–I knew they would prefer to feel that they had safely kept their secret. Yet their devotion had touched me deeply.

War had not broken their spirit. Their selfless action brought a new nobility to human life, gave promise of a greater hope for human society.

About The Author



Archibald Joseph Cronin (1896–1981) was a Scottish novelist, dramatist and physician. A doctor by training, Cronin was one of the most renowned storytellers of the twentieth century. Many of his stories have emerged from his medical career and are noted for their narrative skill, deep social conscience and finely drawn characters. Cronin's books were not only bestsellers but some of them (such as **The Citadel and The Keys of the Kingdom**) were made into successful films and were adapted for radio and television. His novella **Country Doctor** was adapted for a long running BBC radio and TV series.

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